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For the President
27 September 2026



Trump Rejects Iran's Seven-Day Hormuz Roadmap; Blockade and Oil Squeeze Persist

We assess that the US-Iran war will grind on for now after President Trump on 26 September publicly rejected Tehran's seven-day roadmap to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and restart talks, calling the terms "not acceptable" and asserting Iran "is losing so badly." The two sides remain far apart on sequencing, but both are keeping the mediation channel open — a sign neither wants the war to widen even as neither will move first.

- Iran floated the plan at the UN General Assembly on 25 September: within a week it would permit navigation through the strait and resume nuclear talks *if* Washington first lifts its naval blockade of Iranian ports, waives oil sanctions, and releases frozen funds. We judge the up-front US concessions are the sticking point.
- Foreign Minister Araghchi said Iran "will not back down" on its conditions and is awaiting a "definitive" US response through Qatari intermediaries rather than reacting to Mr. Trump's public remarks. NSA reporting corroborates that the proposal was passed via Doha.
- President Pezeshkian, in a *Face the Nation* interview aired 27 September, said Tehran has "no trust" in Washington after past talks gave way to strikes, and tied any progress to a phased framework echoing an earlier understanding reached in Islamabad.

For Washington, the economic stakes are the real pressure point. The strait has been effectively closed for roughly seven months — the most severe oil-supply disruption on record by volume — keeping Brent above \$100 since the spring and near \$106 late last week.

- We assess the blockade-for-navigation swap remains the most plausible off-ramp, but sanctions relief and frozen-fund release are politically hard for the President to grant while he judges Tehran to be losing.
- A decision point comes when the mediators relay Washington's formal answer; continued rejection likely prolongs the price premium and the global fuel strain into winter. Watch Gulf shipping insurance rates and any Iranian move to escalate at the strait as the near-term barometers.

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Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

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Russia Leans on Winter Strike Campaign as Both Sides Deepen the Air War

We assess that Moscow is shifting toward a prolonged long-range strike campaign to try to break Ukraine over the winter, after 2026 battlefield gains failed to deliver a decisive result. ISW's 26 September assessment judges the pressure is forcing President Putin to rethink his theory of victory and bet on sustained aerial bombardment rather than a ground breakthrough.

- Ukraine's General Staff logged 221 engagements on 26 September, heaviest around Pokrovsk and Kostiantynivka; Russia paired the ground fight with mass drone and glide-bomb strikes that killed civilians across several regions.
- Ukraine is hitting back at Russia's energy and defense base: overnight 25–26 September Ukrainian deep strikes struck an oil refinery in Krasnodar Kray along with a defense-industrial plant and air-defense sites. Overhead imagery indicates fresh damage at the refinery.
- We judge Kyiv's key vulnerability entering winter is thin defense against jet-powered Geran-type drones at scale; Russian launches ran to roughly 160–170 per night late in the week.

On the diplomatic track, Russian Foreign Minister Lavrov on 26 September accused European governments of doing "everything they can" to block peace talks and met Germany's foreign minister — the first such contact since the 2022 invasion — while President Zelensky dismissed Mr. Putin's stated conditions as a "lame excuse" to avoid negotiating. For Washington, the signal is that a near-term ceasefire remains unlikely and that allied unity on sustaining Ukraine through the winter is the variable to watch.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NSA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
27 September 2026



Hezbollah Drone Strike Tests the Lebanon Ceasefire on Nasrallah Anniversary

We assess the Israel-Hezbollah ceasefire remains intact but increasingly brittle after an overnight exchange on 27 September, timed to the second anniversary of Hezbollah leader Hasan Nasrallah's death. The tit-for-tat is consistent with a managed low-intensity standoff rather than a slide back to open war — but the margin for miscalculation is narrowing.

- Hezbollah launched an explosive drone at Israeli troops in the southern Lebanon security zone; no injuries were reported. The Israeli Air Force struck back at drone- and missile-launch sites and other infrastructure, with Lebanese sources reporting several killed.
- Separately, Israel said it killed a militant involved in the 7 October 2023 abduction of hostages, underscoring that Israeli operations continue despite the truce.
- We judge Hezbollah is signaling it retains capability without seeking full-scale escalation, while Israel is enforcing its freedom of action in the buffer zone.

For Washington, the risk is that a stray casualty spike drags the US-brokered arrangement off track just as Prime Minister Netanyahu — facing a 27 October election and sharpening attacks on his opposition — has domestic incentives to project toughness. We expect continued limited strikes and a realistic possibility of a sharper flare-up if Hezbollah misjudges Israel's threshold.

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Beijing Presses Washington on Taiwan Even as the Trade Truce Widens

We assess that last week's Xi-Trump summit bought a tactical easing in trade tensions while leaving the core strategic dispute over Taiwan unresolved — and, from Beijing's view, nudged in its favor. The pattern is classic: compartmentalize commerce, press on sovereignty.

- Follow-through from the 24–25 September visit firmed up over the weekend: the two sides reached consensus on roughly \$30 billion in non-sensitive trade, with Beijing committing to sizable US coal purchases in 2027–28 and both extending their tariff truce.
- On Taiwan, Mr. Xi pushed Mr. Trump to move from Washington's standing line that it does not "support" independence toward actively "opposing" it. Taipei denounced the framing as a "distortion of facts," insisting only Taiwan's people can decide their future; the US envoy in Beijing said American policy is unchanged.
- We judge Beijing will keep testing whether it can extract rhetorical shifts through summitry and economic sweeteners rather than coercion.

For Washington, the near-term task is reassuring Taipei and allies that a trade thaw does not presage a softer Taiwan posture. We expect continued PRC gray-zone pressure — including seabed and cable-mapping activity near the island — and will watch whether any US language drifts toward Beijing's preferred formulation.

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For the President
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Adversaries and Middle Powers Rally an Anti-Unilateralism Chorus at the UN

We assess that this week's UN General Assembly is being used by Russia, China, Iran, and a broad bloc of middle powers to frame the US-led order — and specifically the Iran blockade — as illegitimate "unilateralism," advancing a multipolar narrative that erodes diplomatic cover for US freedom of action. The chorus is rhetorical for now, but the alignment it signals is the strategic story.

- Russian Foreign Minister Lavrov used his 26 September address to promote a multipolar order and met Arab officials on the Iran war and Gaza; China's Vice President Han Zheng told the Assembly Beijing opposes "unilateral military actions" — a thinly veiled reference to the US campaign against Iran.
- The wave of recent recognitions of Palestinian statehood by the UK, France, Canada, Australia, Belgium, and others — and mass walkouts before Mr. Netanyahu's speech — underscore Israel's, and by extension Washington's, deepening isolation on the Gaza file.
- We judge none of this constitutes a coordinated bloc yet, but the convergence of Russian, Chinese, and Iranian messaging around a shared anti-US frame lowers the diplomatic cost for third states to hedge away from Washington.

For Washington, the practical effect is a harder environment to assemble coalitions and sustain pressure campaigns. We expect the theme to persist through the general debate and to resurface in votes on Iran sanctions and Middle East resolutions in the weeks ahead.

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For the President
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Gaza Ceasefire Holds Into Its Second Year as the Toll Passes 74,000

We assess the Gaza ceasefire in place since October 2025 continues to hold in broad terms, halting the heaviest fighting even as intermittent Israeli strikes persist against what Israel calls emerging threats. The humanitarian ledger keeps climbing and the political fallout keeps widening.

- Gaza health authorities reported on 27 September that the cumulative Palestinian death toll since the war began has surpassed 74,000. The figure cannot be independently verified but is the standard reference for scale.
- Signs of Israel's isolation accumulated over the weekend: Mauritius denied landing rights to an Israeli flight, and Ireland's national team voted to play a fixture against Israel while planning a protest gesture.
- Mr. Netanyahu, campaigning ahead of the 27 October election, went after five opposition leaders coordinating against him — a reminder that Israeli domestic politics now shapes the pace of any next phase.

For Washington, the priority is keeping the truce from unraveling and reviving a governance-and-reconstruction track. We expect continued low-level strikes and slow diplomatic movement, with the Israeli election the key near-term variable.

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Notes

Sudan. Sudan's Doctors Network on 26–27 September accused the Rapid Support Forces of looting a hospital, the latest in a pattern of attacks on medical facilities as the civil war grinds on. A recent UN report found outside suppliers have sharply upgraded both sides' drone capabilities, letting them strike well beyond the front. We judge the humanitarian collapse and external arms flows will keep widening the conflict's regional footprint.

Yemen. Yemeni government forces reported strikes on Houthi positions in Taiz province over the weekend, a reminder that the internal Yemeni war persists alongside the Houthis' Red Sea threat. We assess the group remains a wildcard that could reactivate shipping attacks in step with the wider Iran confrontation.

Iraq. Baghdad and Washington agreed to resume US dollar cash shipments to Iraq after a monthslong suspension. We judge the move eases a liquidity squeeze in the Iraqi economy while giving Treasury continued visibility into flows it watches for sanctions evasion tied to Iran.

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